

Sabalenka wins in China and works on being kinder to herself

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Aryna Sabalenka began her China Open tournament with a win over Mexico's Renata Zarazua. She also spoke about trying to be kinder to herself when she plays tennis.

Sabalenka, **ranked** number two in the world, won 6-1, 6-3. The match lasted 63 minutes. She hit 11 **aces**. An ace is a serve that lands where it should and that the other player cannot touch.

It was her first match since losing her world number one ranking and her US Open title to Elena Rybakina in September.

Sabalenka's most recent **titles** came in March. She won Indian Wells and the Miami Open one after the other. Winning both tournaments is called the Sunshine Double.

Sabalenka said expecting more from herself can sometimes push her forward. But it can also use up her energy. She said she was working on being easier on herself.

Her next **opponent** was set to be Czech player Nikola Pietrangeli in the third round. Pietrangeli had come close to beating Sabalenka at the Berlin Open in June.

Tennis matches are divided into **sets**. Sabalenka won both **sets** against Zarazua to move on in the tournament.

Word Treasure

ranked -- Placed in an order based on results.

aces -- Legal serves that the other player does not touch.

titles -- Tournament championships won by a player.

opponent -- The player someone competes against.

sets -- Parts of a tennis match made up of games.

Background you need

Tennis matches are divided into sets, which are made up of games.

The Sunshine Double means winning Indian Wells and the Miami Open.

Break it down

Introduces Sabalenka's China Open win and her comments about self-pressure.

Gives the score, match length and explanation of aces.

Recalls her September changes and March tournament wins.

Explains her high expectations and names her next opponent.

Ends with a brief explanation of tennis sets.

Why it matters

The story shows how a successful athlete thinks about expectations and the energy they can take.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Sabalenka beat in her opening China Open match?

- ☐ (A) Nikola Bartunkova
- ☐ (B) Elena Rybakina
- ☐ (C) Aryna Sabalenka
- ☐ (D) Renata Zarazua

2. How long did the match against Zarazua last?

- ☐ (A) 63 minutes
- ☐ (B) 93 minutes
- ☐ (C) 73 minutes
- ☐ (D) 83 minutes

3. What is an ace in tennis?

- ☐ (A) A legal serve the receiver cannot touch
- ☐ (B) A short pause between two tennis sets
- ☐ (C) A long rally that ends at the net
- ☐ (D) A missed shot that lands beyond the court

4. Which two tournaments did Sabalenka win in March?

- ☐ (A) Indian Wells and the Miami Open
- ☐ (B) The Berlin Open and the Miami Open
- ☐ (C) The Berlin Open and the China Open
- ☐ (D) Indian Wells and the China Open

5. What did Sabalenka say high expectations can do?

- ☐ (A) Remove her pressure or guarantee a title
- ☐ (B) Change her serve or shorten every match
- ☐ (C) Choose her opponent or decide her ranking
- ☐ (D) Push her forward or use up her energy

6. Who was set to face Sabalenka in the third round?

- ☐ (A) Renata Zarazua
- ☐ (B) Aryna Sabalenka
- ☐ (C) Nikola Bartunkova
- ☐ (D) Elena Rybakina

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Aryna Sabalenka: She said expecting more from herself can push her forward but can also use up her energy, and she is trying to be easier on herself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):